

CoARA Action Plan UCLouvain 2024-2029

About

Since 2006, UCLouvain, through the Rectors' Council (CRef), has signed *The European Charter & Code for Researchers* which has enabled us to analyse our human resources practices and implement actions to harmonise them using a series of tools:

- Jobs & Funding
- Career Development
- Information & Assistance
- Partnering
- Worldwide

In 2011, UCLouvain received the [HR Excellence in Research](#) label from the European Commission, which recognises the quality of the various action plans put in place to improve recruitment, working conditions, careers, and services for researchers.

Through the *Human Resources Strategy for Researchers* label (HRS4R - Euraxess), UCLouvain is committed to promoting a favourable environment for research, training, and career development. UCLouvain's Euraxess 2020-26 strategy comprises twenty-four actions divided into five areas: HRS4R action plan, Internationalisation, Recruitment, Working conditions, and Training and careers.

Since 2016, UCLouvain has also been an active member of [The Guild of European Research-Intensive Universities network](#), a network whose aim is to help Europe tackle major societal challenges by promoting the role of research in finding innovative solutions.

In 2019, our institution joined the European university alliance [Circle U.](#) initiative to promote international mobility and experience thanks, among other things, to the formation of joint programmes. Circle U. is described as "a research-intensive and interdisciplinary alliance working to provide outstanding education, research and innovation to contribute to more sustainable, democratic and healthier societies" (<https://www.circle-u.eu/about/mission/#toc1>).

Finally, in October 2023, UCLouvain has signed the [Agreement on Reforming Research Assessment](#), thereby becoming a full member of the [Coalition for Advancing Research Assessment](#) (CoARA), alongside more than 700 other institutions worldwide. Through this action plan, our institution undertakes to respect and fulfil the commitments of the agreement to the best of its ability.

Priorities and vision shared with CoARA

UCLouvain committed to a strategic plan called 'Horizon 600' (2021–2025), which set out the direction of the institution and its future activities. Through this plan, UCLouvain aimed to consolidate its position as an open, innovative university and to intensify its activities as a collaborative, socially engaged institution. The plan was divided into five priority action plans focusing on: a) student support; b) human resources; c) internationalisation; d) economic, ecological and social transition; e) Open Education and Open Science.

Some of the commitments set out in these priority action plans were already in line with those of [CoARA](#): the first three commitments of the Open Education and Open Science plan (see the Open Science Plan section below) and the sixth commitment of the Human Resources plan (see the Human Resources Plan section below).

“Open Science Plan:

- Anchoring Open Science, in all its dimensions, in the actions of research institutes: UCLouvain is committed to making Open Access, Open Data and Open Source common practices in the scientific community.
- Nurturing an Open Science culture at all university levels: This culture aims to improve the quality and reliability of research through principles such as inclusiveness, fairness, equity and sharing.
- Increasing its international visibility through its investment in Open Science: UCLouvain actively contributes to national and international networks promoting Open Science such as Circle U. and The Guild.”

Human Resources Plan:

- Promoting diversity, gender equality and inclusion: UCLouvain continues its commitment and combines action, analyses, and surveys to emphasise openness, balance and equity.”

Since 2015, UCLouvain has been fully committed to promoting equality, as demonstrated by the adoption of its first Gender Equality Plan ([GEP](#)) (2015-2024) which met the mandatory requirements of the European Commission. The second Gender Equality, Diversity & Inclusion Plan ([GEDIP](#)) for 2024-2027 has been released and includes an intersectional dimension, recognising that people’s experiences are influenced by multiple interconnected factors (e.g., gender, age, race and social status). This ambitious plan is structured around five concrete priorities and specific measures that are aligned with the university's values and international criteria, such as those of Horizon Europe. Two specific areas mirror some of the objectives outlined in CoARA’s commitments: ‘Gender Equality in Recruitment and Career Progression’ (Area 3) and ‘Integration of EDI aspects in research and teaching’ (Area 4).

Since the beginning of 2024, UCLouvain has participated in an 18-month inter-university project funded by the Wallonia-Brussels Federation (FWB). The main objective of this project was to develop an inter-university platform for good practices in research evaluation. In line with [CoARA](#)’s commitments, the project was divided into five work packages (WPs), each led by one of the institutions:

Work package	University leader
WP1: Defining new modalities for research assessment	UCLouvain
WP2: Open Science	ULiège
WP3: Ethics	ULB
WP4: Scientific integrity	UMONS
WP5: Training and career development	UNamur

UCLouvain oversaw the WP1, which involved defining new modalities for research assessment, and identified potential improvements in order to fulfil the commitments of CoARA. This project will be referred to as “FWB/CoARA” for the remainder of the document.

The implementation of the CoARA action plan (Axis 4) is now one of the main priorities of the [UCLouvain 2024–2029 Strategic Research Plan](#). The first version of the plan was presented to the Academic Council in July 2024, and its implementation has already begun. Actions classified as “high priority” in the plan below are being implemented gradually, in consultation with researchers and with the specific characteristics and international requirements of each field taken into account. Implementation comprises five components:

- A change in the Research Council's funding evaluation criteria, which will consider new types or formats of scientific contribution while maintaining the requirement for scientific rigour. For example, this will enable the recognition of inter- and transdisciplinary project preparation and valorisation initiatives.
- Start by evolving the evaluation of projects submitted to the Research Council.
- Next, evolve the evaluation of researchers' CVs at the time of recruitment and promotion applications, in close collaboration with the Vice-Rector for Staff Policy.
- Work on this development with our Belgian (FWB and Flemish) and European partners (mainly within The Guild and Circle U.), who are signatories to the agreement, to effect a cultural change in the medium and long term.
- Consolidate the outcomes of the FWB/CoARA project by contributing to the PINDARE inter-university platform hosted on the CRef website (<https://pindare.cref.be/fr/>) and by allocating resources to implement the action plan.

This strategic research plan comprises a number of actions that are aligned with the objectives and commitments set out in the CoARA agreement. These include:

- Axis 2: supporting inter- and transdisciplinary research
- Axis 3: aiming to realise the potential for societal impact and valorisation
- Axis 5: developing Open Science practices

The plan also includes training and support actions for researchers and evaluators (within the Research Council).

Action plan

By signing the Agreement on Reforming Research Assessment on 9 October 2023 and registering as a member of the CoARA coalition, UCLouvain has committed to publishing an action plan detailing all the measures to be implemented in order to fulfil the 10 commitments of the agreement.

Although research cannot be isolated from the other two institutional missions of teaching and service (to society and to the institution), this document is primarily intended for all those involved in research evaluation within our institution:

- The Research Council, whose role is primarily to evaluate research proposals originating from various calls (e.g., Concerted Research Actions (ARC), Special Research Funds (FSR), etc.)
- Recruitment committees, which perform all evaluations related to the recruitment of new members (e.g., academic positions, qualified researcher positions, etc.)
- Promotion boards, whose role is to evaluate research career progression (e.g., confirmation of position at the end of probationary period or promotion to a higher grade)

This document proposes actions that will not generate excessive administrative complexity or the need to deploy resources that are not currently available. The emphasis is on steps that are already underway and will continue to evolve, feeding into the ongoing reform of research evaluation at UCLouvain. However, new aspects and initiatives that will be implemented will also be detailed.

Commitment 1: Recognise the diversity of contributions to, and careers in, research in accordance with the needs and the nature of the research.

UCLouvain already:

- Is committed to [Open Education & Open Science](#) via three commitments linked to Open Science: *"Anchor Open Science, in all its dimensions, at the heart of the actions of the research institutes"*, *"Nurture a culture of Open Science at all levels of the University"* and *"Increase its international visibility through its investment in Open Science"*.
- Is committed to supporting inter- and transdisciplinary research through several initiatives that address multiple needs, such as freeing up time to prepare inter- and transdisciplinary projects, recognising inter- and transdisciplinary research in researchers' CV evaluations and training researchers in interdisciplinary research.
- Uses a tool called the Concerted Individual Academic Project (PAIC) to facilitate career monitoring. This project is defined at the beginning of an academic career and is designed to facilitate career development monitoring (e.g., at the end of the probationary period). It is flexible and evolving. It was not created for the purpose of control.
- Considers a wide range of contributions when evaluating research proposals and careers.
 - Research proposals:
 - UCLouvain already uses a wide range of criteria to evaluate research proposals (e.g., for the Research Council, the entire career path is considered and a narrative CV is requested in addition to a factual CV).
 - Research careers:
 - Three main aspects are assessed when recruiting a new academic member or evaluating their career: the research profile is examined in line with the teaching profile and services provided to society and to the institution.

UCLouvain will:

- **High priority** – Rethink the rating system for assessing calls for projects managed by the Research Council, in order to recognise the diversity of contributions more effectively and harmonise the procedure across different calls.
- **High priority** – Engage in training Research Council members to enable them to evaluate research beyond their own discipline and across different disciplines.
- List instances (outside the Research Council) in which a narrative CV could be required. In these instances, ensure that the use of the narrative CV is benchmarked, and its relevance discussed, to avoid any misuse or excess (e.g., avoid drifts linked to the description of personal life rather than professional life). In every other research assessment object or body, ensure that narrative is included and considered.
- Ensure that all evaluation commissions systematically define the list of criteria prior to assessments and share them publicly (as accurately as possible).
- Raise awareness among the actors involved in research assessment of the importance of valuing the involvement of researchers. For example:
 - o In the third mission: services to society and to institution.
 - o In Open Science approaches (such as Open Access publications, FAIR data, etc.).

Commitment 2: Base research assessment primarily on qualitative evaluation for which peer review is central, supported by responsible use of quantitative indicators.

UCLouvain already:

- Evaluates the research proposals granted via its internal funds (i.e. funds managed by the Research Council) using a peer-review approach that relies primarily on qualitative evaluation.
- Uses quantitative indicators rarely, and when this is the case, such criteria are contextualised and always support qualitative criteria. The Research Council's first criterion for evaluation is an overall appreciation of the project after a comprehensive reading.
- Calls on external experts when needed to consolidate the quality of peer-reviewing (e.g., when assessing large-scale research projects such as ARC or when recruiting for a new academic position).
- Considers the opinion of the peer reviewers to improve its assessment practices. As part of the FWB/CoARA project, 34 interviews were carried out with members of evaluation committees (including commissions or juries that evaluate research proposals, promotion committees and recruitment committees) to survey their assessment needs and constraints, and to identify potential improvements in the responsible use of quantitative indicators.

UCLouvain will:

- **High priority** – Implement improvements for a responsible use of quantitative indicators, based on the results of the FWB/CoARA project, together with the partner universities from the FWB.
- Increase awareness of the bias of quantitative metrics and the advantages of going to a more qualitative evaluation approach (e.g., by creating a recommendation guide to raise awareness of metric drifts, or by disseminating existing documents on this topic within the institution, particularly among the actors involved in research evaluation).

***Commitment 3:** Abandon inappropriate uses in research assessment of journal- and publication-based metrics, in particular inappropriate uses of Journal Impact Factor (JIF) and h-index.*

UCLouvain already:

- Does not use the JIF to assess the quality of a candidate's publications as part of the Research Council's research proposal evaluation process.
- Uses the H-index responsibly: for example, for research projects, candidates are asked to provide abstracts of the five most relevant publications, justifying their choice. Metric indicators are moderated, taking into account the context of the relevant discipline, and the majority of project calls ask for a narrative CV to complement the factual CV.

UCLouvain will:

- **High priority** – Implement improvements for a responsible use of quantitative indicators, based on the results of the FWB/CoARA project, together with the partner universities from the FWB.
- Increase awareness of the bias of quantitative metrics and the advantages of going to a more qualitative evaluation approach (e.g., by creating a recommendation guide to raise awareness of metric drifts, or by disseminating existing documents on this topic within the institution, particularly among the actors involved in research evaluation).

***Commitment 4:** Avoid the use of rankings of research organisations in research assessment.*

UCLouvain already does not use the ranking of research organisations for research assessment purposes.

***Commitment 5:** Commit resources to reforming research assessment as is needed to achieve the organisational changes committed to.*

UCLouvain already:

- Committed resources by hiring a full-time employee to work on the FWB/CoARA project for 18 months. The project aimed to develop an inter-university platform of good practices for research evaluation in line with CoARA. This position will be maintained in order to continue implementing institutional reform beyond the end of the project.
- Mobilised resources as part of the HSR4R Euraxess label through the creation of an internal action plan defined at UCLouvain (in particular through action 6, "Create a recruitment guide for everyone who has a responsibility for recruiting researchers", and action 11, "Preserve a quality research environment", sub-action "Examine the value of reforming the way research is evaluated (towards a more quantitative evaluation)").
- Dedicates time of the members of the Research Council (18 members) to:
 - o Steer the process of reforming research assessment within institutional processes.
 - o Evaluate internal research project calls each year (e.g., FSR, ARC, etc.).
- Dedicates the time of the members of all recruitment commissions (a unique commission of a minimum of three members is created for each open position) and promotion commissions (a minimum of three members) to all evaluations linked to the career assessment of researchers.

UCLouvain will:

- Continue to contribute in-kind to the CoARA agreement by:
 - Dedicating the time of the members of the Research Council to:
 - Steer the process of reforming research assessment within institutional processes.
 - Contribute to the reflection on the use of more qualitative indicators in research evaluation processes, in collaboration with the stakeholders (bottom-up approach).
 - Dedicating time to the administrative coordination and operationalisation of the implementation of the reform, through the members of the Research Department (ADRE).
 - However, UCLouvain will ensure that the processes of the action plan do not overburden the involved resources.

Commitment 6: Review and develop research assessment criteria, tools and processes.

UCLouvain already:

- Led the working group focusing on defining new indicators for research evaluation as part of the FWB/CoARA project, with the aim of moving towards a more qualitative evaluation of research.
- Produced, as part of the FWB/CoARA project, an institutional inventory of practices (criteria used, procedures and composition of committees) for the assessment of research projects led by the Research Council, and in the assessment of research careers (promotion and recruitment committees).
- Participated, as part of the FWB/CoARA project, in the production of [a joint repository of practices](#) of the five institutions of the FWB, and proposed a list of best practices, areas for improvement, and suggested layouts for both research project assessment and research career evaluation (promotion and recruitment).
- Dedicates the time of the Research Council to engage in ongoing reflection on its research funding tools and evaluation processes (e.g., annual meetings).
- Implemented guidelines for handling conflicts of interest within the Research Council, prior to any evaluation of its calls, and in the context of recruitment commissions.

UCLouvain will:

- **High priority** – Based on the results of the FWB/CoARA project, together with the partner universities from the FWB:
 - Identify and analyse new indicators, tools and procedures for evaluating research.
 - Propose indicators, tools or procedures for evaluating research that take into account all contributions.
 - Establish avenues of appropriation within FWB institutions.
- **High priority** – Reformulate and improve the application forms for research project grant calls so that they are in line with the institutional practices.
- Conduct a survey to gather feedback from those who are assessed, building on the assessors' consultation, paying particular attention to the perspectives of those who do not receive funding, across all levels.

- Raise awareness of gender bias within the institution, and particularly among the actors of research evaluation (e.g., by creating a guide for evaluators setting out these recommendations and by providing training).
- The Research Council, in consultation with the UCLouvain libraries, will share existing documentation or, if necessary, draw up a document setting out guidelines and recommendations for high-quality peer-reviewed publications and for avoiding publications in predatory journals.

Commitment 7: Raise awareness of research assessment reform and provide transparent communication, guidance, and training on assessment criteria and processes as well as their use.

UCLouvain already:

- Contributed to the development of an Open, Transparent, Merit-based Recruitment (OTM-R) guide ([e-book](#)), which promotes good recruitment procedures and practices.
- Initiated actions to improve transparency in recruitment practices:
 - o Through the creation of [a single portal](#) for all academic vacancies. Positions are advertised in a harmonised format on the UCLouvain portal and relayed via Academic Positions, Euraxess and specialised channels.
 - o Through the creation of a single application form for career advancement and a single application form to apply for academic positions.
- Promotes the international recruitment of researchers (e.g., using the [Euraxess Jobs platform](#)).
- Is fully committed to promoting equality through the Gender Equality, Diversity & Inclusion Plan 2024-2027 ([GEDIP](#)), specifically in Area 3 (Gender Equality in Recruitment and Career Progression), and Area 4 (Integration of EDI aspects in research and teaching).
- Provides on-demand oral feedback:
 - o When evaluating research proposals:
 - Via a face-to-face meeting with the President of the Research Council for researchers who have submitted a research proposal.
 - o When evaluating research careers:
 - Via a face-to-face meeting with the Vice-Rector for Staff Policy after a recruitment campaign.
- Implemented a rebuttal phase in the evaluation procedure of the ARC, the institution's most important funding tool.
- Created a [poster](#), as part of the FWB/CoARA project, to inform the institution's scientific community that work is underway on reforming research evaluation.

UCLouvain will:

- **High priority** – Improve the transparency of the evaluation criteria used by the various ad hoc committees.
- **High priority** – Clarify its evaluation procedures for research projects at the stage of calls for proposals.
- **High priority** – Reformulate and improve the application forms for research project grant calls so that they are in line with the institution's practices.
- Promote communication on CoARA's commitments and on all institutional evaluation procedures within the university community.

Commitment 8: Exchange practices and experiences to enable mutual learning within and beyond the Coalition.

UCLouvain already:

- Has been part of the FWB/CoARA project on the reform of research evaluation, developing an inter-university platform of good practices for research evaluation ([PINDARE](#)) in line with CoARA. This project involved the five universities of the FWB: ULB, ULiège, UMONS, UNAMUR and UCLouvain.
- Contributed to the development of an OTM-R guide ([e-book](#)) on good recruitment procedures and practices, as part of an inter-university project.
- Attends the CoARA General Assembly and thematic webinars to stay up to date with the latest trends.
- Is an active member of The Guild's Research Careers and Assessment Working Group and participated in the first physical meeting in Vienna in June 2025.

UCLouvain will:

- Continue collaborating with its partner universities in the FWB beyond the inter-university FWB/CoARA project.
- Promote communication on CoARA's commitments within the university community.
- Continue to attend the CoARA General Assembly and some thematic webinars on the topic, in order to stay up to date with current trends.
- Continue collaborating with and being involved in international networks working on similar issues, such as The Guild's Research Careers and Assessment Working Group.

Commitment 9: Communicate progress made on adherence to the Principles and implementation of the Commitments.

UCLouvain already:

- Informed its internal governance bodies about its engagement in signing the CoARA agreement and its participation in the FWB/CoARA project.

UCLouvain will:

- **High priority** – Create a dedicated webpage on the institutional portal explaining the CoARA coalition and the university's commitment to meeting its obligations.
- Report the progress made on this action plan annually to its internal governance bodies, through the Research Council's annual report.

Commitment 10: Evaluate practices, criteria and tools based on solid evidence and the state-of-the-art in research on research, and make data openly available for evidence gathering and research.

UCLouvain already:

- Made a benchmark on qualitative evaluation criteria for research projects and academic career evaluation through the FWB/CoARA project.

UCLouvain will:

- **High priority** – Publish its action plan and progress made on its institutional website.
- **High priority** – Publish its action plan and progress made on the CoARA website.

- Take greater account of the literature of research on research (e.g., by inviting an expert to the annual Research Council meetings or the joint meeting of the Research Council and the steering committee of the Heads of Research Institutes).

